

A Personality Trait-Based Interactionist Model of Job Performance

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Evidence for situational specificity of personality–job performance relations calls for better understanding of how personality is expressed as valued work behavior. On the basis of an interactionist principle of *trait activation* (R. P. Tett & H. A. Guterman, 2000), a model is proposed that distinguishes among 5 situational features relevant to trait expression (job demands, distracters, constraints, releasers, and facilitators), operating at task, social, and organizational levels. Trait-expressive work behavior is distinguished from (valued) job performance in clarifying the conditions favoring personality use in selection efforts. The model frames linkages between situational taxonomies (e.g., J. L. Holland's [1985] RIASEC model) and the Big Five and promotes useful discussion of critical issues, including situational specificity, personality-oriented job analysis, team building, and work motivation.

Meta-analyses have shown repeatedly that personality measures can predict job performance fairly well under certain conditions (e.g., Barrick & Mount, 1991; Hough, 1992; Salgado, 1997; Tett, Jackson, & Rothstein, 1991). Research in this area has been motivated largely by practical objectives targeting discovery of traits related to performance in selected jobs. Recently, efforts have been made (Adler, 1996; Chatman, Caldwell, & O'Reilly, 1999; R. Hogan & Shelton, 1998; Motowidlo, Borman, & Schmit, 1997; Warr, 1999) to move beyond this descriptive approach to consider the theoretical bases of personality trait–performance linkages. True to the aims of the scientist-practitioner, it is hoped that, through better understanding of such relationships, the potential utility of personality measures in selection might be more fully realized.

Our goal is to present a person–situation interactionist model of job performance that lays the groundwork for specifying the conditions under which particular personality traits will predict performance in particular jobs. It is intended to help explain why personality trait measures show situational specificity in predictive validity, with respect not only to relationship strength but also to direction (i.e., positive vs. negative; Tett, Jackson, Rothstein, & Reddon, 1999). Our model offers bases for improving yields from personality measures in fitting people with jobs, including applications in teams and attempts to vitalize personality traits with motivational force in heightening appreciation for them as theoretical—not just descriptive—constructs. In setting the stage for the model, we review evidence showing situational specificity in personality–performance linkages, consider existing approaches to conceptualizing the personality–performance relationship, and in-

troduce a concept of *trait activation*, forming the heart of the proposed model. We present the model and identify and discuss several hypotheses drawn from it. We then use the model to integrate existing situational taxonomies and the Big Five in summarizing recent research and hypotheses for future study. Finally, we apply the model in several ways, targeting better use of personality information in work settings.

Situational Specificity of Personality–Job Performance Relations

Results of several meta-analyses generally support the use of personality measures in selection efforts. In a widely cited study, Barrick and Mount (1991) aggregated trait–performance relations for a variety of job families in terms of the Big Five. Conscientiousness was found to predict performance in all job families, with corrected mean correlations ranging from .20 for professional jobs to .23 in sales (uncorrected values range from .09 to .13). Other traits showed more modest validity in some job categories. Extraversion, for example, yielded corrected means of .18 and .15 for managers and sales people, respectively (uncorrected *M*s = .09 and .11). These findings show potential for personality to predict job performance and have spawned considerable productive research in this area (Mount & Barrick, 1998).

Barrick and Mount's (1991) results are provocative in other ways that have gone largely unnoticed. In particular, situational specificity is evident throughout Barrick and Mount's aggregations, including the few cases where mean validity is relatively strong. Thus, although Conscientiousness predicts managerial performance .22 on average (after correcting for artifacts), 10% of validities in this area are expected to fall below .09, and 10% above .35. In police jobs, the corrected mean and lower 90% credibility value (CV) are .20 and –.03, respectively. Corrected mean validity is .18 for Extraversion in managers, but the lower 90% CV is .01. The proportion of variance due to artifacts is less than 75% in 14 of 25 trait–job combinations (56%), and in eight cases (32%) it is less than 50%. A related point is that validity varies in direction (i.e., positive vs. negative) within trait–job combinations. Bidirectionality is a special case of situational specificity. It is particularly troublesome in standard meta-analysis

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A preliminary version of this article was presented at the 14th Annual Convention of the Society for Industrial and Organizational Psychology, Atlanta, Georgia, May 1999. We gratefully acknowledge the helpful comments of Deidra Schleicher, Wendy Casper, Anthony Abalos, and Bob Hogan regarding earlier versions of this article.

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because averaging estimates of true positive and true negative population values will substantially underestimate validity through direct cancellation of effect sizes (Tett et al., 1999). Bidirectionality is most evident in Barrick and Mount's results for Agreeableness in predicting effectiveness in sales (mean validity = 0, 90% CV = -.31) and skilled and semiskilled jobs (.06, -.16); for Openness to Experience in managerial (.08, -.12), skilled and semiskilled (.01, -.15), and sales jobs (-.02, -.22); and for Emotional Stability in sales jobs (.07, -.18). Barrick and Mount's results are often cited for the uniformly positive mean validities for Conscientiousness. They are at least as noteworthy, however, in showing situational specificity and bidirectionality in diverse trait and job categories.

Stronger evidence for situational specificity in trait-performance relations derives from a large-scale meta-analysis reported by Hough, Ones, and Viswesvaran (1998) regarding managerial effectiveness. They considered personality more specifically than did Barrick and Mount (1991). Extraversion, for example, is separated into dominance, sociability, and energy level. A large number of relations involving diverse criteria have 90% CVs that are negative, and substantially so in several cases. Sociability, for instance, has a mean corrected validity of -.02 and a lower 90% CV of -.31. In many other cases, where relations are more uniformly positive (e.g., Dominance with overall performance), there is still substantial nonartifact variance, suggesting the presence of untapped situational moderators. Averaging meta-analytic results across all predictor-criterion combinations (which is not the same as meta-analytically averaging all the validities) yields an overall mean corrected validity of .09 and a mean lower 90% CV of -.13. These results, like many of Barrick and Mount's, suggest situational specificity, and bidirectionality in particular, for personality measures in predicting job performance.

That personality-job performance relations vary in strength and direction across situations calls for more careful consideration of situational moderators. Classifying validities by job and trait categories (e.g., the Big Five) is a step in the right direction, but situational specificity within those categories indicates that we need to look deeper into the nature of work situations and the psychological processes mediating trait-performance linkages. Personality traits are considered in a number of models of work motivation and job performance. A notable example is growth need strength in Hackman and Oldham's (1980) job characteristics model. Relatedly, Barrick, Mount, and Strauss (1993) showed that Conscientiousness is related to job performance by way of self-set goals. Targeting specific traits fosters insight into personality processes, but the generalizability of the proposed mechanisms to other traits is unclear. To highlight the unique contributions of the proposed model, we briefly describe several models of job performance specifying a role for personality.

Existing Models of Personality Trait-Performance Relations

Using data from Project A, Borman, White, Pulakos, and Oppler (1991) extended Hunter's (1983) model of supervisory ratings of job performance in part by adding achievement orientation and dependability as antecedents. These traits were found to contribute directly to performance ratings as well as indirectly through job

knowledge, disciplinary actions, and other mediators. Campbell, McCloy, Oppler, and Sager (1993) proposed that job performance, considered in terms of eight categories (e.g., job-specific task proficiency, written and oral communication task proficiency), results from the multiplicative combination of declarative knowledge (e.g., facts), procedural knowledge (e.g., skills), and motivation (e.g., effort). Each performance category has its own unique combination of predictors, with personality recognized as an antecedent of knowledge, skills, and motivation. Motowidlo et al. (1997) suggested that personality variables (a) contribute to performance by way of habits, skills, and knowledge, and (b) are linked more strongly to contextual performance criteria, such as enthusiastic persistence, volunteering for extra-role assignments, and helping others, than to more traditionally conceived task performance variables. The latter sorts of criteria are predicted more strongly by cognitive ability with those effects mediated by a distinct set of habits, skills, and knowledge. Crossover between the two main predictors is possible (e.g., personality can affect task performance through some task-related mediators), but these effects are secondary.

Each of the models described above either ascribes peripheral roles to personality variables in explaining job performance ratings or targets specific traits, leaving unspecified the mechanisms by which personality traits are linked to performance. Such approaches are valuable, but it bears consideration that personality may play a more central role and afford greater yields with clarification of general processes. Along those lines, R. Hogan and Shelton (1998; cf. R. Hogan, 1991; R. Hogan & Roberts, 2000) offered a socioanalytic view of trait-performance relationships. Unlike earlier models, theirs focuses exclusively on personality as a direct rather than mediated predictor. The featured elements of this perspective are that (a) people are motivated to get along with others and to get ahead, (b) personality viewed by the self (i.e., identity; "from the inside") is to be distinguished from personality viewed by others (i.e., reputation; "from the outside"), (c) the effect of specific personality dimensions on performance is moderated by social skills, and (d) performance appraisal is identified as playing a key role. In short, the rater (supervisor, subordinate, peer) evaluates the ratee's performance given the "rewardingness" of past encounters. Ratees who meet the rater's needs, through a combination of motives and social skills, receive favorable evaluations.

The proposed model, like those described above, is intended to clarify the role of personality in understanding and predicting job performance. It is distinct, however, in two important respects. First, it explicitly focuses on situations as moderators of personality trait expression and in evaluation of those expressions as job performance. In doing so, it is unique in offering direct and testable explanations of bidirectionality and situational specificity of personality-job performance relations, described above. Second, the proposed model is unique by identifying general mechanisms by which any personality trait can be expected to be linked to job performance. As such, it offers a unifying framework for further study of personality traits in practical as well as theoretical pursuits. The conceptual core of the model is the interactionist process by which personality traits are expressed, considered here as *trait activation*.

The Trait Activation Process

Personality traits are dominant constructs in psychology and have been defined in a variety of ways (cf. Phares & Chaplin, 1997). For present purposes, they are conceived to be *intraindividual consistencies and interindividual uniquenesses in propensities to behave in identifiable ways in light of situational demands* (Tett & Guterman, 2000, p. 398). This definition highlights five key points relevant to prediction and personnel selection.

1. Within-person consistencies are what allow predictions about future behavior on the basis of past behavior.
2. Between-person uniquenesses create the need for trait descriptions (e.g., Norman, 1963) and, in selection, allow some people to be hired over others.
3. As propensities, traits are latent potentials residing in the individual; understanding what triggers them is critical for understanding the role of personality in the workplace.
4. Trait inferences are interpretations of overt behavior; we see traits by what we see people do.
5. Behavioral interpretation (as expressing one trait or another) is context-dependent; understanding trait expression calls for consideration of relevant situational features.

The above definition is consistent with *person-situation interactionism*, an enduring theme in personality research (Bowers, 1973; Ekehammar, 1974; Endler & Magnusson, 1976; Epstein & O'Brien, 1985; Pervin, 1985; Snyder & Ickes, 1985; Weiss & Adler, 1984). Notable applications to work settings include B. Schneider's (1983, 1987) attraction-selection-attrition (ASA) model and Chatman's (1989) model of person-organization fit. The ASA framework holds that people (a) select organizations they perceive as having similar values, (b) are further selected in the screening process, and (c) leave when fit is poor. Organizational values (culture, climate) disseminate from founders and others in upper management, resulting in a self-perpetuating homogeneous workforce. Similarly, Chatman (1989) argued that person-organization fit occurs when the organization's and the individual's values are congruent. Personal outcomes of fit include extended tenure, extra-role behaviors, and value change. Certain personality traits can moderate fit. Being open to influence, for example, can facilitate conformity to existing norms. Both models specify roles for personality in understanding organizational behavior, but neither gives clear direction as to how traits are related to job performance. The proposed model offers a unique interactionist approach to understanding trait-performance relations.

The principle of trait activation holds that personality traits are expressed as responses to trait-relevant situational cues (Tett & Guterman, 2000). The idea goes back at least as far as Henry Murray (1938), who suggested that situations exert "press" on individuals to behave in trait-related ways. Thus, if one wishes to assess nurturance, one must observe people in situations where nurturance is a viable response. Similar points have been raised by Allport (1966), Alston (1975), Bem and Funder (1978), Snyder

and Ickes (1985), and Chatman et al. (1999) and are explicitly recognized in McClelland, Atkinson, Clark, and Lowell's (1953) use of the Thematic Apperception Test (TAT) for assessing achievement motivation, Rosenman's (1978) Structured Interview for assessing Type A personality (cf. Tett et al., 1992), Endler, Edwards, and Vitelli's (1991) measurement of state versus trait anxiety, and Latham, Saari, Pursell, and Campion's (1980) work on the situational interview. The common thread linking all these contributions is the deliberate provision of cues for expressing targeted traits.

The idea of "press" suggests the concept of *situation trait relevance* (Tett & Guterman, 2000). A situation is relevant to a trait if it is thematically connected by the provision of cues, responses to which (or lack of responses to which) indicate a person's standing on the trait. For example, a situation where someone cries out for help is relevant to the trait of nurturance because responding to that cue by helping would suggest high nurturance and ignoring it would suggest low nurturance. Trait activation is the process by which individuals express their traits when presented with trait-relevant situational cues.

In a direct test of the trait activation idea, Tett and Guterman (2000) showed that correlations between self-report trait measures and trait-relevant behavioral intentions are stronger in situations providing appropriate cues for trait expression. The moderator effect holds within situations targeting the same trait. For example, trait-intention correlations in each of 10 risk-taking situations themselves correlated notably with risk-taking trait relevance ratings for those same situations (i.e., second-order correlation = .66, $N = 10$ situations). Correspondingly, cross-situational consistency in behavioral intentions were higher across situations similarly high in trait relevance (e.g., second-order correlation for risk taking across the 45 risk-taking situation pairs = .55). Key findings are that (a) situations can vary reliably in the provision of cues for expressing targeted traits (i.e., trait relevance) and (b) behavioral expression of a personality trait covaries with trait-relevant situational cues.

Trait relevance is the essentially qualitative feature of situations that makes it reasonable to expect expression of one trait rather than another. It is distinct from situation strength in the same way a radio station is distinct from the volume at which it is played. Strong situations tend to negate individual differences in response tendencies by their clarity (i.e., everyone construes them the same way) and the severity of extrinsic rewards (Mischel, 1973, 1977; Snyder & Ickes, 1985; Weiss & Adler, 1984). Finding oneself in a burning building, for example, leaves few options with respect to leaving late. Similarly, being given the choice of showing up to work on time or being fired will reduce variability in the expression of traits underlying tardiness. More fundamental than situation strength, however, is whether or not the situation provides cues for trait expression. (Notably, both examples raised above—burning building, job site—are relevant to tardiness.) The greatest variance in trait-expressive behavior may be expected in weak situations where extrinsic rewards are modest or ambiguous but only in those situations that are relevant to the given trait.

Trait relevance and strength are distinct situational characteristics, and both are required for a full appreciation of situational factors involved in personality expression. Consider the following examples. An employee is assigned to an office left in disarray by the previous occupant. This situation is relevant to the trait of

3. Path 3 captures trait activation stemming from the nature of the work itself, including all the day-to-day tasks, responsibilities,

and procedures that traditional job analysis might reveal as defining the given job. This is where employee selection specialists usually derive their expectations and explanations for personality trait-based job performance. For example, methodicalness is generally expected to predict performance in accounting, which entails a lot of detailed record management. Cues at this level can be distracting as well. A methodical manager, for example, might be indecisive on account of spending too much time on details (i.e., analysis paralysis; Chatman et al., 1999; Tett, 1998). The distinction between demands and distracters is discussed in greater detail in a later section. A job can be defined in terms of trait-relevant cues that go beyond those considered at the task level, as represented in connection to Paths 4 and 5.

4. Path 4 captures trait-relevant cues that arise in working with others. They include needs and expectations of peers, subordinates, supervisors, and clients regarding an individual's effort, communication, and related socially prescribed behaviors, as well as team functions (e.g., production vs. support service). Unlike task-level demands, social (i.e., group-level) demands are generally unrecognized in selection efforts and other formal interventions; however, they are potentially as important. Consider, for example, two sales positions equal in tasks, duties, products, and so forth. The supervisor in one position is authoritative, and the supervisor in the other is democratic. What it takes to be successful in these two cases could be quite different with respect to authority-related traits: Someone high in the need for autonomy might excel under democratic but not autocratic supervision. This raises two points. First, traits that make a good employee in terms of social demands may be different from those operating at the task level. Second, traditional and even personality-oriented job analysis might easily ignore social demands, focusing instead on task demands, which are more concrete and accessible. Social demands are an area in which personality traits may be underused in current person-job fit efforts. Application of the proposed model in team building is discussed toward the end of this article.

5. Organizational climate and culture have been described as "the personality of the organization" (Cherrington, 1989, p. 494) and are inferred from a variety of macrolevel organizational characteristics (e.g., structure, policy, reward systems; B. Schneider, Brief, & Guzzo, 1996). Trait-relevant cues at this level can be distinct from those at the task and social levels. As an extension of the previous example, consider two sales positions identical in task and social demands. One job is at a company with a clear and rigid hierarchical structure and the other where hierarchical boundaries are fuzzy. The organizational structures in the two companies may entail correspondingly unique trait-relevant expectations of work behavior (e.g., conservative authoritarianism vs. liberal egalitarianism). In support of the potential for organization-level situational effects on trait-performance relations, Day and Bedeian (1991) found that accountants high in work orientation performed especially well in an organizational climate characterized by warmth (e.g., friendliness) and fair rewards. This shows that important situational factors (i.e., climate warmth in this case) need not share the same taxonomic origins as the trait brought into action (i.e., work orientation). Such complexities impede prediction and highlight the need to consider multiple levels of analysis in understanding the role of personality in the workplace.

Evaluation and Job Performance

6. Path 6 represents the distinction between work behavior and job performance, clarifying that the value of a given behavior depends on context. The contextual nature of job performance ("contextual" here is intended in an interactionist sense) is the essence of placement and career choice decisions: Behaviors ill-suited to the demands of one job may be ideal in meeting the demands of another. The distinction provides a basis for understanding bidirectional trait-performance relations, discussed earlier. The fundamental process (i.e., trait activation) linking traits, situations, and work behavior holds regardless of the job and organization. What varies is the value placed on the behavior. Nurturance, for example, may be expressed in managers in two different jobs by similar forces (i.e., trait activation), but the resulting behavior may be judged effective in one case and counterproductive in the other.

7. Path 7 denotes the critical role of evaluation in determining the strength and direction of relations between personality traits and job performance. The source of Path 7 generally is job demands, which serve not only as cues for trait activation and sources of main effects but also as reference points for evaluation. Evaluation is influenced by expectations centered at each of the task, social, and organizational levels discussed previously. The most concrete expectations pertain to the task as traditionally targeted in job analysis and the identification of performance goals. Social demands will enter the evaluation process less formally. A team leader may be disposed to view a member's work behavior favorably if the individual appears to fit in to the dynamics of the group, even if task performance is suboptimal; the reverse is also possible. Performance ratings may be influenced as well by perceived fit with organizational values, policies, structure, and so forth. Whether evaluations based on social and organizational demands are accurate or fair is a separate issue, considered below in the context of performance appraisal.

Motivation

Motivational applications of personality in the workplace have an illustrious history (e.g., Alderfer, 1972; Hackman & Oldham, 1976; Herzberg, 1974; Maslow, 1970; McClelland, 1985). Paths 8 and 9 capture two distinct motivational forces regarding personality expression at work. (For personality traits not considered motivational, for example, possibly cognitive styles, the proposed model may be less relevant in this respect.)

8. Path 8 denotes the intrinsic value of personality expression. Personality traits have long been considered as needs or drives, satisfaction of which leads to pleasure and lack of fulfillment to displeasure (e.g., Allport, 1951). Perhaps clearest among early trait theorists, Murray (1938) stated that needs give rise to behavior that "changes the initiating circumstance in such a way as to bring about an end situation which stills (appeases or satisfies) the organism" (p. 124). The motivational force of traits is also clearly captured in interpersonal approaches to personality (e.g., Leary, 1957; Sullivan, 1953) and related circumplex models (Carson, 1969; Kiesler, 1983; Plutchik & Conte, 1997; Wiggins, 1979), which hold that personality trait expression is a fundamental part of human nature and failure to express one's traits leads to anxiety (Bakan, 1966; Cote & Moskowitz, 1998; Wiggins & Trapnell,

1996). In the broader model proposed here, an individual will seek out and be satisfied with tasks, people, and organizational features affording opportunities for expressing his or her particular array of personality traits.

9. Path 9 denotes the extrinsic part of personality-based motivation. In addition to the inherent pleasure of expressing one's personality, pleasure (and displeasure) may also result indirectly from others' reactions. A trait expression (i.e., behavior) viewed by others as favorable, in light of task, social, and/or organizational demands, is likely to be met with praise, acceptance, and tangible rewards (e.g., monetary incentives, promotion opportunities). Trait expressions viewed as unfavorable, on the other hand, will elicit negative responses. Thus, an ideal work situation (tasks, people, organization) for any individual is one that offers cues for trait expression per se (as per Path 8) and one where trait-expressive behavior is valued positively by others. By the same token, work situations providing cues for trait expressions valued negatively by coworkers will be problematic by the incompatibility of intrinsic and extrinsic rewards.

10. Path 10 captures the straightforward notion that behaviors offering intrinsic or extrinsic rewards are more likely to be engaged. The distinction between Paths 8 and 9, in conjunction with Path 10, clarifies the meaning of *strong situations* in the context of personality trait expression. Specifically, a strong situation is one whose extrinsic rewards (Path 9) overpower individual differences in intrinsic rewards associated with trait expression per se (Path 8); variance in trait expressive behavior will be maximized when extrinsic rewards are weak or unclear.

Dynamic Interaction

11. Path 11, linking work behavior back to situations, reflects the fact that people actively influence their environments and the people in them (Bandura, 1978; Funder, 1991; Magnusson & Endler, 1977; B. Schneider, 1987; Snyder & Ickes, 1985). Weiss and Adler (1984) referred to this as "dynamic interaction." We suggest there are two main types of such feedback loops relevant to the proposed model. Positive feedback occurs when a person's work behavior causes the continuation or increase of trait-relevant situational cues, and negative feedback occurs when a person's work behavior reduces or eliminates such cues. Examples of the former (one at each of the task, social, and organizational levels) include (a) a conscientious person organizing his or her workspace to facilitate efficient work completion (a mechanism that may help explain why orderliness and achievement orientation are positively related, the former, in a sense, serving the latter); (b) an extrovert bringing out extroversion in co-workers, thereby prompting further cues for sociable interaction (a basis for compatibility discussed in a later section); and (c) a bureaucrat sustaining a detail-driven culture, in which cues for rule-following thrive. Examples of negative feedback (again, one per level) include (a) a competitive salesperson winning clients over in a stable market, leaving fewer remaining challenges; (b) a devil's advocate (perhaps low on agreeableness) discouraging all who would offer ideas for critical evaluation; and (c) an entrepreneur developing novel products requiring manufacture by established methods, thereby restricting cues for creativity. Such feedback mechanisms are critical for understanding work settings as dynamic and evolving systems,

with personality expression both a cause and an effect of situations.

All told, personality–job performance relations can be considered the result of two interrelated mechanisms. The first, *trait activation*, describes work behavior as responses to trait-relevant situational cues operating at multiple levels. Trait expression is intrinsically rewarding, and tasks, people, and organizational features offering trait-expression opportunity, regardless of extrinsic rewards, will tend to be found desirable. The second component, *evaluation*, describes job performance as valued work behavior in which value is centered at the three noted levels. Trait expression will be rewarded positively or negatively, depending on whether or not work behaviors meet key job demands. Situational factors are examined more closely in the next section. We then return to the model to draw and consider a number of testable hypotheses.

Situational Features Relevant to Personality Expression at Work

Work situations operating at each of the task, social, and organizational levels can be relevant to personality expression in several ways. The most obvious case is a *job demand*, defined here as an opportunity to act in a positively valued way. Job demands include tasks and duties found in a job description, as well as less formal prescriptions carried in group norms and organizational features. Their strength depends on the degree to which rewards are contingent on the responses they engender, but they are rarely so strong as to preclude individual differences. A related trait-relevant situational feature is a *distracter*. It is different from a job demand in that responding to a distracter interferes with performance. For example, a sociable manager might be distracted from her duties in an organization populated by extroverts. Distracters are not typically recognized as a formal part of the job (although they might be). Contrary to demands and distracters, a *constraint* negates the impact of a trait on work behavior by restricting cues for its expression. A supervisor might be constrained in the expression of sociability by the dispersion of subordinates over a broad geographical area (i.e., where face-to-face meetings are rare). A *releaser* is a discrete work event that counteracts a constraint. A physically isolated supervisor might find an outlet for sociability at a company planning retreat. The gathering would effectively release the manager's sociability, allowing it to correlate with work behavior, and possibly, job performance. Finally, a *facilitator* makes trait-relevant information that already exists in a given situation more salient: Our retreat attendee might be especially attuned to the opportunity for social interaction through notification of an after-hours social event.

The trait-relevant situational features described above permit comparison along three key dimensions, shown in Table 1. *Activation status* determines the relevance of a trait for predicting performance and contributes to relationship strength. Job demands, distracters, and releasers are trait activators, constraints are deactivators, and facilitators are uniquely multiplicative in that they amplify the activation or deactivation effects of the other features. *Behavioral value* distinguishes trait expressions judged positively versus negatively in ratings of job performance and helps determine the direction of relationship. As noted above, this is the main distinction between demands and distracters. Constraints, releasers, and facilitators can affect performance positively or nega-

Table 1
Comparisons Among Five Trait-Relevant Situational Features and Their Roles in Trait-Performance Relationships

Comparative dimension	Role in trait-performance relationship	Situational feature ^a				
		Job demand	Distracter	Constraint	Releaser	Facilitator
Activation status	Strength	+	+	—	+	x
Behavioral value	Direction	+	—	+/-	+/-	+/-
Frequency	Predictability	Chronic	Chronic	Chronic	Acute	Acute

^a (+) Activation status = strengthens the personality-job performance relationship; (—) activation status = weakens the personality-job performance relationship; (x) activation status = increases the other features' effects on the strength of the personality-job performance relationship; (+) behavioral value = makes the personality-job performance relationship positive; (—) behavioral value = makes the personality-job performance relationship negative.

tively. For example, constraining impulsivity in detailed planning may be desirable but less so in creative pursuits. *Frequency* denotes the centrality of the characteristic to a given job and determines the predictability of a relationship. Job demands, distracters, and constraints are generally ongoing (i.e., chronic) and definitive parts of the work setting and thus will allow relatively stable predictions (i.e., for a particular job). Releasers and facilitators tend to occur as acute events, undermining predictability.

On the basis of the forgoing analysis, trait-performance relations can be expected to be strong and positive to the degree that the tasks, people, and organizational features making up the given work setting provide cues for trait expression and to the degree that demands outweigh distracters. If there are constraints on trait expression, they should operate on distracters, not on demands. Releasers and facilitators will strengthen a positive relationship if operating in favor of demands, weaken the relationship (or strengthen a negative one) if operating in favor of distracters, but in general they will make the relationship less predictable. They are also likely to be less influential than demands, distracters, and constraints, which are more constant and definitive features of the work setting.

Some Key Hypotheses

Our model identifies several critical conditions affecting the relationship between personality and job performance, offering hypotheses for study. Specifically, a given personality trait will correlate positively with job performance in a given work setting to the degree that (Hypothesis 1) workers vary in their level of the trait; (Hypothesis 2) cues for trait expression are provided by (a) job tasks, (b) other people in the work setting (coworkers, clients), and/or (c) organizational features (e.g., structure, culture); (Hypothesis 3) trait-expressive behavior contributes consistently positively to organizational effectiveness; and (Hypothesis 4) work situations are relatively weak (i.e., extrinsic rewards are not so powerful as to negate individual differences in trait-expressive behavior). For example, many managers handle complex data in situations where errors are costly. Methodicalness will predict performance positively in such cases if (1) participants vary in methodicalness, (2) the work setting offers cues at one or more levels to express methodicalness, (3) methodical behavior uni-

formly meets job demands, and (4) extrinsic rewards are not so severe as to motivate everyone to behave the same way.

Hypothesis 1 warrants attention because people tend to self-select and are further selected for a job based on their levels on important traits (e.g., B. Schneider, 1983, 1987). The resulting range restriction attenuates trait-performance relations. Hypothesis 2 is the trait activation hypothesis. The example seems clear because management, dealing with data, and methodicalness are conceptually aligned. Suppose, however, that the job comes with a computerized data management system with automated updates customized to local needs. Here, the demand for methodicalness would be constrained and so too the relation between methodicalness and job performance. Constraints may vary widely from job to job and are suitable targets for personality-oriented job analysis (see below). Hypothesis 2 also warrants consideration in terms of dynamic interaction presented as Path 11 in the model. People actively change their work situations (B. Schneider, 1987; Weiss & Adler, 1984). Maintaining or increasing cues for trait expression (i.e., positive feedback loop) may result in continued or strengthened predictive validity, whereas decreasing or eliminating cues (i.e., negative feedback loop) may weaken validity. Such possibilities raise important questions regarding the temporal stability of validity within settings, calling for longitudinal assessment of trait-relevant cues (e.g., through job analysis) and corresponding validation of trait measures.

Hypothesis 3 derives from the evaluation component of the model. It warrants attention because complexities can arise within, as well as between, levels of trait-relevant cues with respect to value. In the example, methodicalness in management can be counterproductive (Chatman et al., 1999; Driskell, Hogan, Salas, & Hoskins, 1994). A senior accountant, for instance, may need to make prompt decisions in the face of incomplete information. The opportunity to seek detailed clarification could distract a methodical person, thereby delaying a decision and jeopardizing timelines. The example raises the possibility of incongruent trait value within levels (task level in this case). Incongruencies can also occur across levels. Methodicalness would be less obvious as a predictor of fit for a senior accountant whose coworkers appreciate impulsivity or who work in an innovative organizational culture. Traits valued incongruently within and across levels will impede prediction. In addition, degree of incongruity may be related to

nonperformance outcomes like job satisfaction (i.e., lower in incongruent situations), role conflict (higher), tenure (lower), promotability (lower), and out-group (vs. in-group) status. It might also guide job design and team building efforts toward minimizing inconsistencies and streamlining the selection process. Such possibilities are considered further below.

Hypothesis 4, representing Paths 9 and 10, warrants attention because situation strength is a matter of degree and people differ in the value they place on extrinsic rewards. Even the threat of termination may not be universally persuasive (e.g., to those dissatisfied with their jobs, who have viable and more desirable alternatives). The strength of work settings and the degree to which they vary in strength is unclear. We suggest situation trait relevance is at least as likely, if not more so, to affect trait–performance relations, per Hypothesis 2.

In sum, the proposed model combines a number of testable propositions regarding the conditions under which personality traits become expressed as valued work behavior (i.e., job performance). The model is designed to be applicable to any personality trait, offering a framework for integrating applied research across trait content domains. In an effort to demonstrate the value of the model in this respect, we attempt in the next section to integrate selected situational taxonomies with the Big Five personality dimensions at each of the task, social, and organizational levels, then outline further applications involving personality at work.

Integration of the Big Five and Extant Situational Taxonomies

The person–environment (P-E) fit literature offers a number of work situation taxonomies relevant to personality. We identified one or two of these taxonomies representing each of the task, social, and organizational levels and considered how they might activate traits organized by the Big Five. Other trait-specific situational features were identified as well. Table 2 links situational and personality content by job demands, distracters, constraints, and releasers as a basis for drawing directional trait-and-situation-specific hypotheses. Facilitators are omitted because they are not expected to be content-dependent (e.g., a training manual could augment cues in any domain). Where possible, empirical findings connecting situational and personality content were incorporated. The extant taxonomies are described below in their intended level of operation.

Task Level

Holland's (1985) RIASEC model is among the most widely known taxonomies of work situations. Derived from job descriptions provided in the Dictionary of Occupational Titles (U.S. Department of Labor, 1977), the six job types and selected descriptors are as follows: realistic (technical, simple, routine), investigative (scientific, complex, analytical), artistic (imaginative, expressive, flexible), social (cooperative, humanitarian, interpersonal), enterprising (goal-driven, sales, leadership), and conventional (data-driven, detail-oriented, clerical). The types are arranged hexagonally and individuals with matching traits are predicted to prefer jobs closest in proximity. Thus, practical individuals will mostly prefer realistic jobs, followed by investigative or conventional jobs, then artistic or enterprising jobs, and be

indifferent to social jobs. DeFrucht and Mervielde (1999) reported relations between the Big Five and preferences for the six job types. Their findings, reflected in the first column of Table 2, suggest that people prefer jobs demanding expression of the personality traits they possess.

Social Level

Schutz's (1958) Fundamental Interpersonal Relations Orientations-Behavior (FIRO-B) model targets group-level fit in work settings. Interpersonal compatibility occurs when one's needs are met by others' actions in three domains: affection (liking others, needing to be liked), control (maintaining control over others, wanting to be controlled), and inclusion (maintaining good relations with others, needing those relations). As noted in Table 2, the first dimension allows classification under Agreeableness, and the latter two as facets of Extraversion: dominance (i.e., control) and sociability (i.e., inclusion). Sundstrom (1999) outlined six types of work groups differing in purpose and, we suggest, corresponding cues for trait expression. Management teams, such as corporate executive teams, engage in planning, budgeting, and policy-making. Project teams, or task forces, are charged to develop components involved in ongoing projects. Parallel teams, including ad hoc committees, advisory boards, and quality control circles, offer advice and make decisions. Production teams, such as assembly lines, generate tangible products on a routine basis tied to rules, specifications, and timely flow of components. Service teams, such as airline attendants and operating room teams, provide support to others. Finally, action and performing teams, like military units, firefighters, and sports teams, are highly specialized and face rapidly changing circumstances requiring quick reactions. Personality traits with special relevance to each team type are suggested in the middle column of Table 2. Thus, for example, we expect that service teams will generally attract and perform best with members who are agreeable and emotionally stable.

Organizational Level

Work demands at this level are captured in organizational culture and climate. O'Reilly, Chatman, and Caldwell (1991) offered a taxonomy of eight organizational cultures. Innovative organizations are characterized by risk-taking and experimentation. Detail-oriented organizations favor analysis and precision in handling details. Outcome-oriented organizations are demanding and bent on achieving results. Aggressive organizations are distinguished by competition and opportunism. Organizations with a supportive culture emphasize information sharing, praising good performance, and supporting workers. Reward-oriented organizations value professional growth and high pay for good performance. Team oriented organizations stress collaboration. Finally, decisive organizations have predictability, low conflict, and controlled decision making. Ostroff (1993) offered a similar taxonomy of nine organizational climate dimensions: participation, cooperation, warmth, growth, innovation, autonomy, achievement, hierarchy, and structure. The various culture and climate dimensions provide unique opportunities for personality trait expression. Judge and Cable (1997) reported relations between the Big Five and preferences for each of O'Reilly et al.'s (1991) culture types. These findings, reflected in the right column of Table 2, suggest that

Table 2

Job Demands, Distracters, Constraints, and Releasers at the Task, Social and Organizational Levels for Each of the Big Five Personality Trait Categories

Situational feature	Source/level ^a		
	Task ^b	Social ^c	Organizational ^d
Conscientiousness			
Job demands	C, E, -A (1) Detail, precision, rule-following Deadlines; high quality task completion	Prd Mgt (3) Precise and explicit communications Responsibility, dependability	Det Out (4): Ach, Hrc, Str (5) Success, competition Loyalty
Distracters ^e	Rules/d for creativity Complexity/d for decisiveness	Norm of punctuality/d flexible schedule Intragroup competition/d for cooperation	Str (5)/d for organizational development Ach (5)/d for company-wide collaboration
Constraints	Automated detail management Clearly structured roles; close supervision	Communications highly formalized Relationships structured for dependability	Highly formalized bureaucracy Limited promotion opportunities
Releasers	Important detailed problem Unique, specific, short-term goal	Forms ill-suited for precise communication Conservative task force	Company compliance to new or changed laws Promotion opportunity
Extraversion			
Job demands	E, S (1) Interpersonal interactions High energy, high profile	Ctl, Inc (2) Highly cohesive teamwork Energetic teamwork	Agg, Out, Tem (4); Prt, Wrm (5) Human relations Festivity
Distracters ^e	Power over autonomous positions Social interaction/d for task locus	Sociability at the water cooler "Party-hardy" norm/d for serious teamwork	Tem (4)/d for solitary, low-profile effort Company party on the eve of a deadline
Constraints	Physical isolation Work autonomy	Introverted coworkers Distributed team	Aut (5) Reserved, "blueblood" corporate image
Releasers	Problem requiring personal interactions Training a new recruit	Office birthday party Practical joke among co-workers	Company picnic Employee-of-the-month award program
Agreeableness			
Job demands	-E, S, -R (1) Helping customers Reliance on others for task completion	Aff (2); Svc (3) Team cohesion Conformity to group norms	Sup. Tem (4): Cop Wrm (5) Friendliness Citizenship
Distracters ^e	Dissatisfied customer/d for thrift Others offer help/d for independence	Groupthink conditions Distracted coworkers/d for firmness	Sup (4)/d for aggression (e.g., take over) Wrm (5)/d for downsizing
Constraints	Isolation from customers Laws ensuring human welfare	Isolation from team members Independent coworkers	Aut (5) Mechanistic atmosphere
Releasers	Problem involving consumer welfare Problem legitimizing help from others	Coworker in an emotional crisis Argument requiring conciliation	Charity fundraiser Sensitivity training
Openness to Experience			
Job demands	A, S, -C (1) Creativity; learning Adventure; frequent travel	A&P, Prj (3) Tolerance of others' ideas Liberal attitude	Inn (4); Prt, Grw, Inn (5) Cutting-edge corporate image Workforce diversity
Distracters ^e	Learning/d for task focus Sensitive information/d for secrecy	Busy-bodies; delinquents Multiple committee opportunities	Inn (4)/d for rules or authority Grw (5)/d for stability or caution
Constraints	Rule-dependency Repetitive, simple tasks	Prd (3) Rigid, conservative coworkers	Str, Hrc (5) Stable, cautious, secure atmosphere
Releasers	One-time travel opportunity Job rotation	Role of devil's advocate in group meeting Focus group; think tank	Strategic planning project Risky market venture
Emotional Stability			
Job demands	E, C, R, I (1) Responsibility with no control over outcomes High risk management	A&P, Svc (3) Handling aggressive coworkers Dealing with norms of pessimism, cynicism	Dec (4); Inn, Aut (5) Atmosphere of uncertainty Rapid growth/charge
Distracters ^e	Repeated failure/justified worry Uncommitted customers/d for hard sell	Back-stabbing/justified "paranoia" Delinquent teammate/justified anger	Sliding profits/d for concern Take-over bid/d for aggression
Constraints	Consistency, predictability Role clarity	High team value on effective planning Cooperative, participative teamwork	Climate of predictability Stress-free culture
Releasers	Sudden crisis Emergency situation	Promotion of a coworker competitor Extreme emotional reaction by a coworker	New management Organizational restructuring

^a 1 = RIASEC job types (DeFruyt & Mervielde, 1999; Holland, 1985). 2 = FIRO-B dimensions (Schutz, 1968). 3 = team applications (i.e., types), Sundstrom (1999). 4 = organizational cultures from Organizational Culture Profile (OCP; O'Reilly, Chatman, & Caldwell, 1991); Judge & Cable (1997). 5 = organizational climate dimensions; Ostroff (1993).

^b Holland model job types: R = realistic; I = investigative; A = artistic; S = social; E = enterprising; C = conventional.

^c Schutz FIRO-B dimensions: Aff = affection; Ctl = control; Inc = inclusion. Sundstrom team applications: Mgt = management team; Prj = project team; A&P = action and performing team; Prd = production team; Svc = service team.

^d O'Reilly et al. organizational cultures: Inn = innovative; Det = detail-oriented; Out = outcome-oriented; Agg = aggressive; Sup = supportive; Tem = team-oriented; Dec = decisive. Ostroff organizational climates: Prt = participation; Cop = cooperation; Wrm = warmth; Grw = growth; Inn = innovation; Aut = autonomy; Ach = achievement; Hrc = hierarchy; Str = structure.

^e Most distracters are followed by a demand ("d") for behavior at the opposite pole of the given trait; such demands are implicit in the remaining cases.

people prefer to work in cultures similar to their own personality. Our judgments involving Ostroff's dimensions are largely consistent with Judge and Cable's results.

The empirical findings and expectations summarized in Table 2 can guide use of personality measures in fitting people with their work environments. The most obvious linkages are those involving job demands where the majority of extant taxonomic dimensions (e.g., RIASEC) are targeted. Predictions may be refined by attending to other situational features. In the case of Openness to Experience, for example, good fit and positive trait–performance relations are expected where job demands include tasks requiring creativity (task level), group norms favor tolerance (social level), and the organization appreciates diversity (organizational level). Distracters weakening (and perhaps reversing) the relationship could include generous opportunities for learning when task focus is required (task level), working with counterproductive coworkers (social level; Murphy and Lee [1994] found that Openness relates positively with workplace delinquency), or feeling liberated by an innovative climate when compliance with organizational authority is critical (organizational level). Constraints on Openness might include repetitive and simple tasks (task level), working within conservative group norms (social level), and dealing with bureaucracy (organizational level). Finally, releasers could include occasional opportunities for travel (e.g., Jackson [1994, p. 70] reported positive relations between travel interest and facets of Openness) or job rotation (task level), to play devil's advocate in a meeting (social level), or for involvement in strategic planning (organizational level). It is the combined effects of all such factors, amplified by facilitators, that determine the strength, direction, and predictability of a correlation between Openness and job performance in a given setting. The current model is offered as an aid in prediction efforts, encouraging identification of situational features beyond those traditionally considered at the task level leading only to positively valued work behaviors.

Further Applications of the Proposed Model

Situational Specificity

Our model offers three explanations for situational specificity and bidirectionality evident in meta-analytic research on personality and job performance. First, work demands can vary across jobs such that the high end of a trait leads to success in some jobs, the low end leads to success in others, and the trait is otherwise irrelevant. Thus, methodicalness may be desirable in a managerial job involving much detailed planning, impulsivity may be desired in a job calling for decisiveness (J. Hogan, R. Hogan, & Murtha, 1992; Robertson, Baron, Gibbons, MacIver, & Nyfield, 2000), and neither high nor low planfulness may be especially helpful in a job neutral or balanced in the demands for meticulous versus expedient decisions. A related mechanism derives from distracters. A gregarious employee may be well-suited to selling advertising (Merrill, 1992) but in other jobs the same individual may spend too much time in idle banter with coworkers (Hayes, Roehm, & Castellano, 1994). In such cases, a trait positively related to job performance under other circumstances is, in a sense, hijacked by undesirable trait-relevant cues. A third basis for situational specificity is performance evaluation. Ambition can be a positive predictor of managerial status (R. Hogan & J. Hogan, 1995), but

ascendant subordinates can receive negative evaluations when seen as having less than the desired level of humility (Day & Silverman, 1989). Negative trait–performance relations may occur in such cases when ratees' traits undermine positive (i.e., mutually rewarding) social relations with raters. Rater bias is an obvious possibility but not the only one. Autonomous workers may be less effective when working under highly directive supervision.

Complexities like those described above support Tett et al.'s (1991, 1994, 1999) assertion that identifying directional moderators in meta-analysis of personality–job performance relations is impeded by the lack of information reported in source articles that would allow such distinctions to be made reliably. Job and trait families are simple and convenient moderators for meta-analytic inquiry. That extroverts, on average, can be better managers (Barrick & Mount, 1991; cf. Furnham & Stringfield, 1993, and Salgado, 1997, for opposite findings based on Chinese and European samples, respectively) is informative, but it does not imply that jobs and traits within those categories are interchangeable with respect to trait expression opportunities and behavioral value (Tett et al., 1999). To make the most of personality data in predicting performance, one needs to know when dominance, sociability, and exhibition (as facets of Extraversion) are desirable and undesirable within, as well as across, job types in light of factors (e.g., team type, norms, culture) that can transcend job boundaries. Use of the proposed or some similar interactionist model in single-sample studies may permit future meta-analytic investigations to compare personality–performance relations according to situational characteristics (e.g., job demands) directly related to trait expression and its evaluation.

Personality-Oriented Job Analysis

Tett et al. (1991, 1999) showed that personality–job performance relations based on confirmatory strategies are twice as strong as those based on exploratory methods. Trait-oriented job analysis (Costa, McRae, & Kay, 1995; Gottfredson & Holland, 1994; Guion, 1998; J. Hogan & Rybicki, 1998; Inwald, 1992; Rounds, 1995) is uniquely tailored to confirmatory studies in this area, facilitating trait selection by closing the gap between descriptions of the job and the sorts of people expected to perform it well. Extant job and related work style taxonomies (e.g., O*NET; Peterson et al., 2001) encourage inferences linking personality with performance in discrete job categories, but tend to focus exclusively on job demands, ignoring the possible effects of less obvious, potentially constraining or distracting situational features. Using the proposed model, personality-oriented job analysis would be a formal process of identifying the cues a job provides for traits whose expressions are of some value to the organization (i.e., positive or negative). Specific attention would be given to trait-relevant job demands, distracters, and constraints, each operating at the task, social, and organizational levels, which collectively define the conditions under which predictions may be advanced. Releasers and facilitators may play an active role, but their identification is limited by their relative infrequency. Guided by suitably specified trait and performance taxonomies, traits likely to offer predictive power, positively or negatively, in a given setting would be systematically exposed.

The Appendix offers an example of how the proposed model might be used for personality-oriented job analysis in the case of

methodicalness. Two examples of possible trait-relevant descriptors of the work setting are provided as demands, distracters, and constraints at each of the task, social, and organizational levels (releasers and facilitators are excluded for the reason noted above). How the ratings are combined (e.g., with or without differential weighting) to yield a trait-value index (i.e., in contributing to organizational effectiveness) is a matter for further consideration. In general, ratings for demands would increase that value, and ratings for distracters and constraints would decrease it. Use of this type of job analysis in a given work setting would be expected to increase accuracy in predicting personality–job performance relations. Application across multiple settings would allow comparisons among the various features (demands, distracters, constraints) and levels (task, social, organizational) in their effects on those relations (e.g., through meta-analytic moderator analysis). Given the prominence of task-level demands in performance measurement, those particular features may prove most powerful in their effects on personality–performance relations. We suspect the other features, however, will contribute meaningfully and practically to personality-based predictions.

Personality-Based Motivational Strategies

Descriptive aims, like those driving meta-analyses in this area, ignore the motivational force of personality traits. In the proposed model, person–job fit is expected where the job provides cues for the expression of traits leading to mutually valued outcomes (e.g., high performance, group acceptance, promotion). Motivation will increase when trait expression opportunities are increased and will increase further when that expression is tied to desired extrinsic outcomes. The task, social, and organizational levels offer unique personality-based motivational strategies. Job design would entail assigning tasks that provide cues for positively valued trait expression (i.e., job demands or desirable releasers). Team building would entail assembling individuals who bring out the best in one another in light of team objectives (as described below). Worker placement, suited to larger organizations, would entail moving individuals to work environments (e.g., plant or department cultures) commensurate with their personalities.

Team Building

Personality contributions to work group processes are receiving increasing attention (e.g., Bowers, Pharmer, & Salas, 2000; Neuman, Wagner, & Christiansen, 1999; Tett & Murphy, 2002). Most research in this area has targeted main effects (e.g., Barrick, Stewart, Neubert, & Mount, 1998; Kickul & Neuman, 2000). Neuman and Wright (1999), for example, reported that Conscientiousness and Agreeableness contributed to team member and overall team performance. The proposed model encourages an interpersonal approach to understanding and improving team functioning. In light of the moderate correlation between group cohesion and performance (corrected meta-analytic $M = .42$; Evans & Dion, 1991), interpersonal compatibility and team performance are considered in turn.

Interpersonal models of personality (Leary, 1957; Sullivan, 1953) and social exchange theory (Foa & Foa, 1974; Thibaut & Kelley, 1959) hold that people are compatible when they offer one another opportunities to express traits that are mutually positively

valued. Some research (e.g., Byrne, 1971; McCleane, 1991) has suggested that people, especially extroverts (cf. Barrick et al., 1998), prefer similar others. Complementarity offers an alternative to similarity by encouraging consideration of how people with distinct traits can be compatible (e.g., Kiesler, 1983). For example, autonomous workers dislike dominant coworkers because the latter restrict opportunities to be autonomous (Tett & Murphy, 2002). Similarity in this light may be subsumed under complementarity: Sociable people prefer others who are similar because sociable behavior by its nature offers cues for others to respond in kind.

Whether mutual trait activation contributes to or interferes with team performance is a critical and complex issue. Teamwork provides cues for the expression of traits required for team tasks (i.e., demands) as well as traits that can interfere with productivity (i.e., distracters). To complicate matters, teamwork offers demands and distracters at both task and social levels. Task-level demands in a team are met by an individual's team role (e.g., Belbin, 1996), i.e., what that person needs to do to contribute directly to the team's success. Social demands are less directly related to team performance. They consist of other members' traits, the activation of which leads to team success. Thus, each member has two responsibilities: one to fulfill his or her team role and the other to bring out the best in other members so that they fulfill their roles (Kichuk & Wiesner, 1998). The key in team building is to find a combination of people who meet both responsibilities. The pitfall in such efforts is that team members may be compatible in counterproductive ways. Compatibility, as described above, is not inherently tied to team performance. A team may be highly cohesive yet unproductive (Kelly & Duran, 1985), suggesting the need to consider cohesion optimality (Evans & Dion, 1991). Further complexity arises in considering variability across teams in task interdependence (e.g., Franz, 1998; van der Vegt, Emans, & van de Vliet, 1998) and the need for heterogeneity (Bowers et al., 2000; Timmerman, 2000). Detailed consideration of these and related factors (e.g., group norms) is beyond current aims. Recognizing that traits are activated and evaluated with respect to cues at multiple levels, however, may contribute uniquely to understanding and improving team performance from a personality perspective.

Design of Personality-Based Selection Systems

Wernimont and Campbell (1968) proposed that predictive validity increases with predictor–criterion similarity. In reviews of work sample validity, Asher and Sciarino (1974) and Robertson and Kandola (1982) found support for “point-to-point correspondence” between predictors and criteria. Despite these successes, there has been a notable lack of research on the psychological bases of such correspondence. Trait activation offers a framework for understanding work sample validity: Among the important “points” that work samples share with real job settings are those activating the traits required for good performance. Conversely, lack of validity could be attributed to the activation of different traits (e.g., evaluation anxiety in work samples, social recognition on the job).

As an extension of point-to-point correspondence, a given trait measure can be expected to correlate with job performance under several basic conditions susceptible to several complicating factors. The basic conditions are that the testing and actual work

situations provide cues to express the same traits and that the trait expressions (as behavior) are judged to affect organizational success. Among the complicating factors are that (a) the cues made available in screening (most often in the form of personality scale items) are qualitatively different from those provided on the job, the former prompting self-description and the latter, overt behavior; (b) identifying the traits activated in each setting may be difficult; (c) responses in each setting are multiply determined (e.g., impression management vs. targeted traits); and (d) performance is evaluated with respect to a complex mix of formally and informally recognized demands, such that ratings may be contaminated by nontask-related perceptions (e.g., group-level fit; see below). The proposed model may not adequately address all such issues relevant to the use of personality measures in selection settings; however, its articulation and framing of complex factors may allow greater accuracy in prediction (e.g., through personality-oriented job analysis and use of screening devices less reliant on self-description, such as interviews, simulations, and, to some extent, biodata). By the same token, it may help explain why the validities of personality-based inferences regarding future job performance rarely exceed .30. The degree to which such validities can be improved on the basis of the proposed model is a matter for future research.

Personality and Performance Appraisal

The performance appraisal process is complex (Cascio, 1991; Guion, 1986). It is doubtful that any single model can adequately frame all relevant factors, and the current model is no exception. It does, however, offer some insight into the role of personality in that process. Task-level demands have the most immediate impact on day-to-day work behaviors, yet raters may be guided by different expectations. The point is not that ratings cannot capture meaningful and important aspects of job performance but rather that traits whose expressions are valued at the task level—and so most likely targeted in screening—may not be the same as those whose expressions are valued by the performance judges. Thus, a methodical accountant successful at the task level may be underrated because his trait lacks fit in a team or culture valuing innovation over rules. Such between-level differences in values and expectations are supported by research showing that supervisors and peers base performance judgments on distinct or differentially weighted constructs (Borman, 1974; Pulakos, Schmitt, & Chan, 1996). They are also consistent with the finding that performance standards at lower levels are affected by senior management (Miller & Droge, 1986; Staw & Sutton, 1992). Thus, higher-level expectations may interfere in ratings of task-level performance.

With further relevance to performance appraisal, the three levels of trait-based cues map roughly onto Motowidlo et al.'s (1997) separation of task and contextual performance. Task performance denotes activities that contribute directly to the organization's technical core, and contextual performance refers to activities supporting the social, psychological, and general organizational environment. The current model suggests that traits activated at the task level will show stronger relations with task performance, whereas those activated at the social and organizational levels will show stronger relations with contextual performance. Borman and Motowidlo (1997) observed that personality variables relate more

strongly with contextual than with task performance (e.g., Motowidlo & Van Scotter, 1994). A possible reason for this is that raters attend more to social and organization-level demands than to immediate task requirements when judging performance. This may be appropriate if performance is attenuated at the task level, owing to selection effects or situational constraints, or if evaluations are to be used for promotion or succession planning in which fit at higher levels carries greater weight. Another possibility is that task performance varies with personality as much as contextual performance does, but raters are influenced less by task than by contextual (i.e., social, organizational) criteria. This suggests rater bias in task performance judgments. Guion (1986) noted that performance ratings can be influenced by ratees' "annoyance factor" and social charm, which is consistent with R. Hogan and Shelton's (1998) claim that personality effects are mediated by the value raters place on past encounters with ratees.

Our model offers a basis for studying such issues in terms of level-specific trait-relevant cues. In particular, we expect that an individual's task performance will be overrated (thereby undermining trait scale validity) when (a) the ratee offers the rater cues to express his or her traits in positively valued ways (i.e., the ratee brings out the best in the rater such that fit at the social level biases task-level performance judgments) and (b) the ratee's trait expression is compatible with organizational features (e.g., culture), even if that expression interferes with meeting task demands (i.e., fit at the organizational level can bias task-level performance judgments, perhaps especially when raters themselves identify closely with the organization). We also expect that personality scale validity in predicting task performance will be higher (c) when traits activated and valued positively at the task level are the same as those activated and valued positively at the social and organizational levels, and (d) when, to the degree that traits are activated and valued differently across levels (i.e., contrary to condition c), performance judges accurately distinguish task-level demands from social and organizational demands. Practical implications include the need to select and train performance judges regarding distinctions among levels in both work demands and the value of trait-expressive behavior. With the aim of improving personality scale validity, these are important questions for future research.

Assessment Center Validity

Although successful in the prediction of managerial effectiveness (Gaugler, Rosenthal, Thornton, & Bentson, 1987), assessment centers have been questioned repeatedly regarding the construct validity of their component measures. In particular, seemingly distinct dimensions (e.g., directing, judgment) correlate much more strongly among themselves within exercises (e.g., in-basket, group discussion) than individually between exercises (Brannick, Michaels, & Baker, 1989; Bycio, Alvares, & Hahn, 1987; Crawley, Pinder, & Herriot, 1990; McEvoy, Beatty, & Bernardin, 1987; Robertson, Gratton, & Sharpley, 1987; Russell, 1987; Sackett & Dreher, 1982). Attempts to overcome the problem (e.g., Harris, Becker, & Smith, 1993; J. R. Schneider & Schmitt, 1992) have made little headway.

The model clarifies that cross-exercise consistency should be expected only if (a) exercises contain similar trait-relevant cues and (b) trait-expressive behaviors are valued equally across exercises. Regarding the first point, Haaland and Christiansen (2002)

found that personality trait scores correlated with trait-relevant assessment center dimensions (e.g., work organization as an expression of Conscientiousness) more strongly in exercises higher in trait activation potential (TAP) and that dimension scores themselves correlated much stronger across high than across low TAP exercises. Regarding the second point (i.e., that behavior must be valued equally across exercises), Zedeck (1986) proposed that assessment center evaluators use exercise-specific "management behavior schema" to organize expectations and interpretations of behavior. If behavioral appropriateness is judged differently across exercises (e.g., methodical behavior is valued positively in one exercise and negatively in another), cross-exercise consistency in trait-expressive behavior (per se) may be washed out by judgments of performance (i.e., valued behavior) in light of exercise-specific demands. The proposed model offers to guide research along such lines by focusing attention on (a) exercise-specific trait-relevant cues and (b) exercise-specific standards against which trait-expressive behavior is judged as performance.

Conscientiousness and Job Performance

Our model can readily account for Barrick et al.'s (1993) finding that goal setting mediates the relation between Conscientiousness and performance: Setting goals offers cues for conscientious workers to express achievement, and achieving goals is directly related to performance. Barrick and Mount's (1991) main conclusion that Conscientiousness is a universal predictor of job performance is similarly explained by the fact that all jobs provide cues for achievement and dependability. It would be imprudent, however, to assume that jobs are invariant in such cues, that expressions of Conscientiousness are universally positively valued (Bunce & West, 1995; Day & Bedeian, 1991; Driskell et al., 1994; Gellatly & Irving, 2001; J. Hogan & R. Hogan, 1993; J. Hogan, R. Hogan, & Murtha, 1992; Reynierse, 1995, 1997; Robertson, Gibbons, Baron, MacIver, & Nyfield, 1999, all reported significant and meaningful negative relations between Conscientiousness and job performance) or that trait-relevant cues at work are restricted to those for Conscientiousness. The meta-analytic evidence reviewed earlier suggests that diverse personality traits can be related to job performance positively, negatively, or neutrally depending on the situation. The proposed model offers a framework for predicting when and how a given trait will predict performance, whether it is a part of Conscientiousness or some other category.

Personality and Ability

Most previous models of job performance (e.g., Borman et al., 1991; Campbell et al., 1993; Motowidlo et al., 1997) have centered on cognitive ability, job knowledge, and related antecedents. Where personality has been considered, it has generally been in terms of specific traits usually as secondary or mediated constructs. The proposed model puts personality at center stage, and the question of how ability might operate invites consideration. The link between personality and ability is complex, and full discussion of this issue is beyond current aims. We suggest the following as a foundation for more extended analysis and inquiry.

One can readily envision an ability-activation process essentially parallel to that proposed here for personality traits (we thank

a reviewer for bringing this to our attention). That is, abilities are latent traits activated by diverse work demands providing cues for their expression, and individuals' responses are evaluated on the basis of how well they meet those demands. Success in meeting demands is taken to indicate high ability, and positive rewards ensue, providing motivational force in future similar situations.

Although generally parallel to the personality-based model, we see three critical differences. First, abilities are always valued positively; being low on a given ability will never be judged a good thing. Personality is more complicated because one pole of a given trait can contribute to performance in some situations, and the opposite pole can contribute in others. This is the primary basis for bidirectional relations evident in meta-analytic research cited at the beginning of the article. The second difference between personality and ability traits regarding their role in performance stems from the unique nature of (most) personality traits as needs. As noted in Figure 1 (Path 8) and discussed in earlier sections, personality trait expression is intrinsically rewarding. Ability traits per se (i.e., not self-efficacy, self-esteem, and other competency-relevant constructs) are not needs and accordingly, carry no intrinsic motivational potential.

The third difference is that personality trait expression depends on ability, whereas the reverse generally does not hold. To express a given personality trait, one must have some ability to carry out that inclination (Murray, 1938). For example, helping someone as an expression of nurturance requires the ability to select appropriate helping behavior (and physical ability to carry it out). Lacking such ability could undermine the expression of nurturance, leading to frustration and disappointment (i.e., negative intrinsic reward). Expressing abilities, although possibly encouraged by congruent personality traits (e.g., achievement striving, competitiveness, intellectance), does not rely on such traits. In our example, general abilities serving helpfulness could be engaged for the promise of extrinsic rewards. Thus, someone low on nurturance might nonetheless offer valuable assistance (as an expression of general ability) with the expectation of a monetary award or perhaps the threat of physical harm or legal liability.

This relatively brief analysis permits a unique comparison between personality and ability traits. Both are activated by trait-specific cues and expressed from motivation instilled by extrinsic rewards. Ability traits can operate independently of personality but lack the force of intrinsic rewards. Conversely, personality traits depend on ability but offer the added impetus of intrinsic reward. To be useful in selection, personality traits must also be valued positively when expressed (i.e., meet job demands), such that intrinsic and extrinsic rewards are aligned. Such alignment is moot with ability as its expression carries no intrinsic value. The upshot of this comparison is that personality and ability contribute uniquely and jointly to prediction. They are companion constructs in that ability provides the "can do" and personality, the intrinsic "will do" behind valued work behavior. Personality poses greater challenges (e.g., susceptibility to distracters; bidirectionality) than does ability. By clarifying some of the complexities involved in personality expression and its evaluation and by guiding the development and use of personality-oriented job analysis, the proposed model promises fuller realization of the potential of personality as a predictive tool.

Implications for Management

Our model has four especially important implications for managers. First, meta-analyses of trait–performance relations in managers (Barrick & Mount, 1991; Hough et al., 1998) call for careful consideration of situational moderators, including those affecting the direction of relationship. The model may help deal with such complexities, guiding trait identification, directional expectations, and predictability in selection settings. Second, managers are not only hired; they also do much of the hiring. The model offers guidance in the use of trait measures to select employees, particularly with respect to personality-oriented job analysis. Third, as a main source of performance ratings used in validating predictor measures, managers need to be cautious when rating subordinates' performance to ensure that criterion variance captures appropriate traits. If traits are selected to predict task performance, then managers need to avoid being influenced by behavior expressing traits relevant in other domains (e.g., contextual performance). Otherwise, validities are likely to underrepresent the true value of personality in selection efforts. Finally, the model suggests how managers might motivate employees based on their personality traits: Workers need appropriate cues for trait expression leading to mutually valued outcomes. Job design, team building, and employee placement offer distinct means of managing trait-expressive opportunities.

Summary and Conclusions

Encouraging meta-analytic findings in the early 1990s (e.g., Barrick & Mount, 1991; Hough, 1992; Tett et al., 1991) vitalized efforts to discover personality traits predicting job performance. That same research has shown that a given trait's value is situationally specific. Looking beyond content, personality-based selection systems are likely to benefit by greater attention to the psychological processes by which traits are expressed in job performance. The proposed model presents an interactionist framework for understanding such processes. It offers to (a) guide personality-oriented job analysis in identifying which traits are likely to correlate with performance on a given job and the direction of those relationships, (b) clarify the boundary conditions for trait-based prediction of job performance and opportunities for methodological refinements, (c) identify means of regulating trait-based motivations underlying valued work behaviors, (d) provide unique process-driven criteria for validating inferences based on personality trait information, (e) promote process-oriented comparisons with other predictor-criterion (e.g., ability–performance) relationships in the search for generalizable principles, and (f) foster discovery of new principles allowing practitioners to take fuller advantage of trait information in work settings.

Several potentially important issues were side-stepped in writing this article. Among those calling for more detailed consideration are (a) further development of strategies for measuring key variables (e.g., trait-relevant demands, distracters, etc.); (b) implications of the distinction between objective and subjective situations (i.e., between what Murray called “alpha” and “beta” press); (c) trait-related cognitive mechanisms and skills mediating situation perception and performance judgment (e.g., cognitive style; sensitivity to and threshold for trait-relevant cues); (d) implications of mediators like habits, skills, and knowledge (Campbell et al.,

1993; Motowidlo et al., 1997); (e) the possibility of interactions among traits and between traits and other variables (e.g., ability; e.g., Hollenbeck, Brief, Whitener, & Pauli, 1988); (f) specificity in predictor and criterion domains with respect to unique variance, diagnosticity, and the bandwidth-fidelity trade-off; (g) the possibility of curvilinear relations prompting consideration of trait level optimality; (h) long-term reciprocal effects between traits and situations (e.g., B. Schneider, 1987); (i) implications regarding the conceptualization and prediction of counterproductive work behavior from a personality perspective (e.g., Robinson & Greenberg, 1998); and finally, (j) legal issues bearing on the use of nontask related demands as bases for personnel decisions. Careful thinking and research in these areas and in those outlined throughout the article promise to shed much needed light on the role of personality in the workplace and the processes by which individuals interact with their work environments.

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Appendix

Hypothetical Personality-Oriented Job Analysis for the Trait of Methodicalness

Methodicalness

Instructions

A number of task, social, and organizational descriptors pertaining to the incumbent's work setting are listed below. Rate each descriptor as to how characteristic it is of the work setting, using the following 0-to-8 scale by placing the appropriate number in the space provided.

0	—	1	—	2	—	3	—	4	—	5	—	6	—	7	—	8
not at all characteristic			somewhat characteristic			moderately characteristic			substantially characteristic			highly characteristic				

Task Level

- Demands ☐ decisions and actions must be clearly documented
☐ planning, problem solving, and implementation must be precise
- Distracters ^{a,b} ☐ information is complex and ambiguous, yet decisions must be made quickly
☐ the future is highly unpredictable and planning must be general and fluid
- Constraints ☐ detail management is automated and accurate
☐ roles and duties are highly structured and under close supervision

Social Level

- Demands ☐ communications with others must be explicit and precise
☐ others rely on the incumbent; must be predictable and dependable
- Distracters ^b ☐ interactions with others are complex and details must be ignored or condensed
☐ punctuality and routine are norms, yet the worker's schedule must be flexible
- Constraints ☐ information is recorded and exchanged with the use of forms
☐ the job is structured to ensure dependability expected by others

Organizational Level

- Demands ☐ bureaucratic policies and principles must be followed
☐ the organization's success depends on a detailed strategic plan
- Distracters ^b ☐ the organization is bureaucratic and faces rapid economic change
☐ the organization is detail-driven but must consider the "big picture"
- Constraints ☐ detailed short-term and strategic plans for the organization are well established
☐ the organization operates in a highly stable external environment

^amethodical workers are susceptible to "analysis paralysis"

^bdistracters have two parts: a cue calling forth a given trait and a demand for behavior falling at the low end of the dimension. These parts might be presented separately in the job analysis and are presented together here for clarity and convenience.